

Heritage Project of the Kerala government with technical assistance from various scientific institutions and laboratories.

KCHR scholars say that indigenous people seem to have settled here when the area was covered by sand beaches. The sand deposits contained shreds of black-and-red ware and other megalithic pottery.

Iron nails, fragments of Roman glass bowls (pillared bowls), shreds of terra sigillata (Arretine ware), Mesopotamian ceramics and Yemenite ceramic torpedo jar were also recovered. "They are evidences of brisk overseas trade and intense occupation," says K.P. Shajan, who pioneered this discovery.

Rouletted wares, which were found extensively in the Eastern Coromandal coast, were reported for the first time in the West Coast. Excavations have also unearthed sand layers containing shreds of Sassanian-Islamic turquoise or blue-glazed pottery dating back to early medieval period (5th to 10th century A.D.).

Prominent findings include remnants of a wooden canoe, which was dug out of a homestead. Carbon dating has estimated its age to be between 1300 B.C. and 100 B.C. Another structure, seeming to be a wharf according to KCHR scholars, was adjacent to a water-front as the water-logged traces indicate. A component of this carefully-built, brick-lined structure was a row of seven wooden pegs, which were possibly used as bollards to secure boats moored to the wharf. Its age is somewhere between 800 and 200 B.C. A 6m

UNWRAPPED: Parthian pottery; remains of stone beads (right)



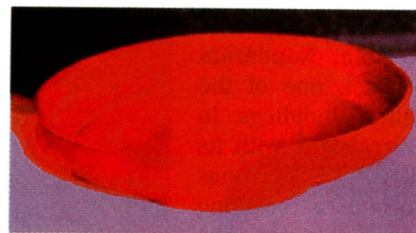
PRICELESS: Wooden canoe; gold jewel (left); earthen plate (right)



x 6m platform with numerous pits assumed to have been used as a warehouse, was found in a trench.

These findings also indicate an unexplained break of habitation between 11th and 16th century as no remnants have been found from that period. However, it appears to have resumed in the 17th and 18th centuries, as indicated by the recovery of shreds of Chinese blue-and-white ceramics. It is inferred that the port town was abandoned between 10th and 17th centuries, which marks the beginning of the colonial occupation. Pallippuram Fort, the first-ever European fort in India, is located less than 5 km from this site.

According to KCHR, this is the first ancient habitation found in Kerala as only burial monuments have crossed the archaeologists' spade so far. "The site offers a fascinating transition story of human habitation from an Iron Age to Early Historic Age and also invaluable insights into the socio-economic formation of early historic Kerala,"



says Cherian. The Archeological Survey of India has given a licence to KCHR for a second excavation, to begin in February 2008. The licence is also for archaeological exploration within 50 km around Kodungallur (supposed to be the hub of ancient Muziris) and underwater explorations. KCHR is to undertake this project in collaboration with the Southern Naval Command and State Archaeological Department.

KCHR has recommended the setting up of a museum here. Roberta Tomber, an authority on ancient Indo-Roman archeology from Southampton University, US, said this evidence has solved a mystery surrounding trade routes as it proves the existence of the legendary port of Muziris. S. Paddayya, director of Deccan College Post-graduate Research Institute says, "These findings have a significance as not many archaeological studies have been done in south India. More detailed excavations have to be done soon." There is no saying what this evidence will lead to next. ■



THE EXISTENCE OF THE LEGENDARY PORT MUZIRIS HAS BEEN PROVED VIA SURROUNDING TRADE ROUTES